

Slow-Cooked Beef Bolognese (Variation 20)

Tags: beef, pasta, italian, dinner, meal-prep | Prep: 20 min | Cook: 180 min | Serves: 12

Ingredients

- 4.5 tbsp olive oil
- 150 g pancetta or bacon, finely diced
- 1.5 large onion, finely diced
- 3 carrots, finely diced
- 4.5 celery stalks, finely diced
- 7.5 garlic cloves, minced
- 750 g beef mince (20% fat)
- 375 g pork mince
- 375 ml whole milk
- 375 ml dry white wine
- 3 tbsp tomato paste
- 1200 g canned crushed tomatoes
- 3 bay leaves
- Freshly grated nutmeg
- Salt and black pepper
- Tagliatelle or pappardelle to serve
- Parmesan to serve

Method

1. Heat oil in a large heavy Dutch oven over medium heat. Cook pancetta until the fat renders, about 5 minutes.
2. Add onion, carrots, and celery (the soffritto). Cook, stirring regularly, for 12 minutes until completely softened and just beginning to colour.
3. Add garlic and cook 2 minutes.
4. Increase heat to high. Add beef and pork mince in batches, breaking up with a spoon. Do not stir constantly — allow meat to brown before turning.
5. Once all meat is browned and no pink remains, pour in milk. Simmer, stirring, until fully absorbed, about 10 minutes.
6. Add wine. Simmer until fully absorbed, about 8 minutes.
7. Stir in tomato paste and cook 3 minutes.
8. Add crushed tomatoes, bay leaves, a scrape of nutmeg, salt, and pepper.
9. Bring to a boil, then reduce to the lowest possible simmer. Cook partially covered for 2–3 hours, stirring every 30 minutes. Add a splash of water if it gets too dry.
10. The finished sauce should be thick, rich, and well-integrated. Discard bay leaves. Season to taste.
11. Toss with freshly cooked pasta and serve with Parmesan.

Chef Tips

- Milk before wine is the Bolognese secret — it tenderises the meat and adds sweetness.
- At least 2 hours of cooking is mandatory; 3 is better. Low and slow is non-negotiable.
- Make double and freeze — the flavour intensifies further after freezing.